



Orthodoxy 201

The Divine Liturgy Part B 4: Liturgy of the Faithful

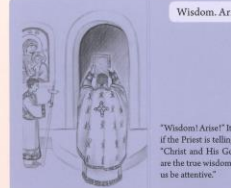
Christ Amongst Us

Blessed is the Kingdom...
BLESSING IS THE CHOROS



The Divine Liturgy is the Kingdom of God. It is at this moment that Christ allows us to enter and see His Kingdom. What a great honor this is, and how very observant we should be at this time!

Wisdom. Arise!



"Wisdom! Arise!" It is as if the Priest is telling us: "Christ and His Gospel are the true wisdom. Let us be attentive."

Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, have mercy on us.
THE TRISAGION HYMN



...One time for the Father, who is Holy, Mighty, and Immortal; one time for the Son who is Holy, Mighty, and Immortal; and one time for the Holy Spirit who is Holy, Mighty, and Immortal...

Wisdom. Arise!
Let us hear the Holy Gospel.



So let us stand silently and calmly—for we are not going to hear a message read from some earthly king, but from the King of the angels!

...that we may receive the King of all...




Upon hearing the Cherubic Hymn, the faithful prepare for the Great Entrance—they ready themselves to welcome the King of Glory who is now entering the Holy City to be crucified for all of us, escorted by the angelic orders.

I believe in one God...



...The faithful, confess their faith in the Holy Trinity—in order to rightly commune of the Bread of Life, a person must have love and confess the true faith.

Let us stand well; let us stand with fear; let us attend, that we may offer the holy oblation in peace.



...carefully consider what is happening: how the Lamb of God is coming to be sacrificed for us; how the precious Blood of the Lord is ready to be poured out into the holy Chalice...

Take, eat, this is my Body which is broken for you for the forgiveness of sins. Drink of it all of you; this is my Blood of the new Covenant which is shed for you and for many for the forgiveness of sins.



We hymn You, we bless You, we give thanks unto You, O Lord...

...the most dread and wondrous mystery of the whole Liturgy is taking place inside the holy Sanctuary. The Bread and the Wine, which up until this moment merely represented the Lord's Body and the Blood, are now truly transformed into His real Body and Blood.

Especially for our most holy, pure, blessed... Lady...



...The Church thanks God for the Patriarchs, Prophets, and Apostles... But, above all, she remembers the All-holy Theotokos... Because the Church knows her to be the bridge which transports mankind from the Earth to the Heavens.

Our Father Who art in Heaven...



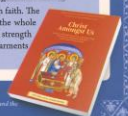
...be amazed at the unfathomable wealth of God's great benevolence towards us! You were ordered to call Him Father—you who are earthly and He Who is of the Heavens, you who are mortal and He Who is immortal, you who are perishable and He Who is imperishable.

With the fear of God, with faith and love, draw near...



The faithful approach the Holy Chalice with faith. The believer is convinced that by partaking of the whole Christ that he will be granted even more strength than those who touched the fringe of His garments and were healed!

This poster accompanies the book *Christ Amongst Us: An Easy to Understand Commentary on the Divine Liturgy According to the Writings of the Holy Fathers and the*
Exposition of the Same by George Dinu and Christina Măntănuș. Divine © Copyright 2017 Newborn Press LLC.



Holy Communion from the Saints

- ◆ *“Jesus declared that the chalice which comes from His creation was His Blood, and He makes it the nourishment of our blood. He affirmed that the bread which comes from His creation was His Body, and makes it the nourishment of our body. When the chalice we mix and the bread we bake receive the Word of God, the Eucharistic elements become the Body and Blood of Christ... Just as bread from the earth, when it receives the invocation of God, is no longer common bread but the Eucharist, made-up of two elements, one earthly and one heavenly, so also our bodies, in receiving the Eucharist, are no longer corruptible, for they have the hope of the resurrection.” St. Irenaeus*

“Let us then partake with full assurance of the Body and Blood of Christ: for in the figure of Bread is given to you His Body, and in the figure of Wine His Blood; that you by partaking of the Body and Blood of Christ, may be made of the same body and the same blood with Him. For thus we come to bear Christ in us, because His Body and Blood are distributed through our members; thus it is that, according to the blessed Peter, we become partakers of the divine nature. Having learned these things, and been fully assured that the seeming bread is not bread, though sensible to taste, but the Body of Christ; and that the seeming wine is not wine, though the taste will have it so, but the Blood of Christ... “strengthen your heart,” by partaking of it as spiritual, and “make the face of your soul to shine.” And so having it unveiled with a pure conscience, you may reflect as a mirror the glory of the Lord, and proceed from glory to glory, in Christ Jesus our Lord:—To whom be honor, and might, and glory, for ever and ever. Amen.”

— St. Cyril of Jerusalem,
Mystagogical Catecheses, IV

Holy Communion

- ◆ The breaking of the bread is a characteristic action signifying the holy Eucharist, encountered in the New Testament (Lk. 24:25, Acts 20:7 and 2:42.26, 1 Cor 10:16) and in the earliest Christian writings – St. Ignatius the Godbearer and Didachae
- ◆ Let us remember that it was in the breaking of the Bread that the eyes of the disciples at Emmaus were open and recognized the Lord – Lk. 24:30-31
- ◆ It is important to understand that the action we follow is exactly the same that of Christ at the Mystical Supper. After calling to remembrance this event we then *do* what the Lord instructed us and commanded us to do.
- ◆ **We must also remember that Holy Communion was instituted by the Lord Himself as a means to be in direct communion with us.**
- ◆ From St Gregory of Nyssa *“a little yeast makes a whole lump of dough like itself (1 Cor. 5:6), in the same way when the body which God made immortal enters ours, it entirely transforms it into itself.”* Catechetical Oration pg. 321

I believe and confess, Lord, that You are truly the Christ, the Son of the living God, who came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the first. I also believe that this is truly Your pure Body and that this is truly Your precious Blood. Therefore, I pray to You, have mercy on me and forgive my transgressions, voluntary and involuntary, in word and deed, in knowledge or in ignorance. And make me worthy, without condemnation, to partake of Your pure sacrament for the remission of sins and for eternal life. Amen.

As I am about to receive holy communion, * O Maker, I pray You not burn me partaking, * since You are fire consuming the unworthy, * but rather purge me of any defilement.

Receive me, today, O Son of God, as a partaker of Your mystical Supper. I will not reveal Your mystery to Your enemies, nor will I give You a kiss, as did Judas. But like the Robber I confess to You. Remember me, O Lord, when You come in Your kingdom.

Seeing the deifying Blood, O human, shudder, * for it is a live coal that burns the unworthy. * The Body of God both deifies my spirit * and feeds my mind in extraordinary manner.

You have enraptured me, O Christ, * with Your longing and transformed me with love divine. * I pray, completely consume * with immaterial fire all my sins. * And count me worthy to be filled * fully with the delight in You, * that I may magnify * both Your Comings, O good Master, exultantly.

How shall I enter into the splendor of Your saints since I am unworthy? For if I dare to enter the wedding hall along with them, my garment will betray me, for it is not fit for the wedding; and then I shall be bound and cast out by the Angels. I pray You to wash away the stains on my soul, and save me, O benevolent Lord.

Benevolent Master, Lord Jesus Christ, my God, let not these Holy Gifts be to my judgment because I am unworthy, but rather for the purification and sanctification of both soul and body and the pledge of the life and kingdom to come. It is good for me to cleave unto God and to place in Him the hope of my salvation.



PREPARATION BEFORE RECEIVING HOLY COMMUNION

Many people essentially identify preparation for receiving Holy Communion with fasting (see next heading). Of course the Church prescribes that in order to receive Holy Communion we should abstain from eating or drinking anything on the morning on which we intend to receive. If we cannot have this minimum preparation then what other efforts do we make to prepare ourselves? However, there are other forms of preparation, besides fasting.

In his preparation, the worshipper confesses his sins, forgives his "enemy" and says the special Communion prayers. This preparation for Holy Communion is both physical and spiritual. Fasting from foods and especially from sins and evil thoughts, the giving of alms, living in chastity and love for fellow man (especially "the least") constitute the main part of the spiritual preparation.¹¹³²

We should be in a state of "spiritual warfare," of struggle against sin and the occasions that lead us to sin, vigilance of soul, a prayerful life in the presence of God, deep humility, clean conscience. It is indispensable to be under spiritual direction, in order not to deceive ourselves. This is not a "moral"

obligation, but a necessity, in order to receive spiritual benefit from the Divine Mysteries. We must prepare the soil of our soul to receive the seed of God's grace, or else it will not germinate and produce. This is pointed out by St. Nicholas Cavaasilas:

Although God gives us all the Holy Mysteries freely and we do not contribute anything previously to Him, but they are in every respect free gifts, He nevertheless demands from us to become susceptible to receive the gifts and to keep them. And He does not transmit sanctification and blessing if we do not behave ourselves in this fashion. He baptizes this way, He chrismates this way, and in this way He feeds us and transmits to us the food of the dreadful Table. And he made this clear from the parable of the Sower. The Sower, it says, went out not to till the soil, but to sow it. And with this saying he shows us that we ought to provide the tilling of the ground and all its preparation.¹¹³³

Preparation for receiving the Holy Mysteries is necessary. "Before receiving Holy Communion is needed struggle and ascetical labor."¹¹³⁴ For if we "labor for the food which perishes" how much more should we labor "for the food which endures to everlasting life, which the Son of Man will give [us]"? (see John 6:27) We have received the wedding

garment (see Mt. 22:11-12) at our baptism and chrismation. We should strive to keep it clean with repentance, humility and charity, and come forth to receive *With fear of God, faith and love*. This is what we should set as our aim, and seek it with all our heart.

The experience of receiving the Lord within us should overwhelm us and lead us to the fear of God, to contrition and to tears. St. Symeon the New Theologian says that we should not commune without shedding tears.¹¹³⁵ Unfortunately, many Christians approach **the heavenly Banquet** as they are, without the proper wedding garment. For their lack of preparation and total disregard of their host, they are tossed "into the outer darkness" (Mt. 22:13). Let us not forget that "we prepare with fasting before the Liturgy so that we may feast with joy and thanksgiving at the marriage supper of the Lamb (Rev.19:9).¹¹³⁶

Would we go to a banquet and talk with friends, listen to the music, dance, but not touch the food offered? And how would the host feel seeing that we did not touch his food? This is what we would be doing if we went to the Divine Liturgy, the Great Banquet, and did not share the

spiritual Food, which is none other than the Lord Himself! The Host sacrificed Himself and makes the effects of His sacrifice available to us, but we refuse His invitation, without being fearful of His warning: "For I say to you that none of those men who were invited shall taste My supper" (Lk. 14:24).

As it is unacceptable to place heavy burdens on the faithful with severe Communion fasting¹¹³⁷ and confession *each time* prior to receiving Holy Communion,¹¹³⁸ so it is unscrupulous to encourage the faithful to come "as they are" to receive each and every time, without emphasizing proper preparation, which involves purity of life, struggle, prayer and tears. Yes, fasting as well, and confession, but the emphasis should be on the "*fear of God, faith and love*." In that sense those who cry, "It is not soup," are justifiable. Many of those who do not receive are better prepared to receive than those who do.

When we approach the Cup, the words of the Apostle should come to mind, "Whoever, therefore, eats the bread and drinks the Cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of profaning the body and blood of the Lord. Let a man examine himself, and so eat of the bread and

drink of the Cup. For any one who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment upon himself" (1 Cor. 11:27-29). St. Symeon the New Theologian explains that "discerning" means to have an "awareness and understanding" of what, or rather Who, is received: "This is how those who worthily eat of this bread and drink of this Cup are united to God: through a perceptive soul and heart, in knowledge and by contemplating the mystery. But those who do so unworthily are devoid of the gifts of the Spirit; they nourish only their body and not their soul at all."¹¹³⁹

We must therefore have an awareness of what we receive, we must be conscious of our participation of the "medicine of immortality," or else it would mean, as St. Symeon again points out, that "the living water has passed through you as through a channel, because it did not find in you a cistern worthy to retain it. In reaching out for your part, while touching the untouchable Mysteries and thus imagining that you eat, you continue to take nothing, to eat nothing, to have absolutely nothing in you."¹¹⁴⁰

"Let no one, however," Archbishop Paul of Finland cautions us, "because of his unworthiness, fail to accept the Lord's invitation heard in the Liturgy, or think that by receiving Communion less often he can prepare for it better and be more worthy. The sense of unworthiness is just the right mood, the only one which permits us to be sharers in God's supreme grace offered to us as a completely free gift."¹¹⁴¹ The last words of St. Cyril's lecture on the Holy Eucharist are, "Sever

not yourselves from the Communion; deprive not yourselves, by the pollution of sins, of these Holy and spiritual Mysteries."¹¹⁴² Only grave sins should keep us away from the Eucharistic Supper.

In order not to offer condemnation instead of life, the Orthodox Church excludes those who do not share Her faith and have no other impediment.¹¹⁴³ This was the practice of the Church since the beginning. That is how the Church Fathers interpreted the words of the Lord: "Do not give what is holy to the dogs" (Mt. 7:6). The Letter to the Hebrews states, "We have an altar from which those who serve the tent have no right to eat" (Heb. 13:10).

We should try to attend Vespers the night before, and the *Orthros* (Matins) Service, which are for everyone, and not just for the priest and the chanter and are the best preparation for the Divine Liturgy. If we come to church past the reading of the Gospel it would be proper to abstain from receiving Holy Communion, in order not to scandalize the faithful.¹¹⁴⁴ Smoking before Holy Communion is worse than eating or drinking. If we cannot abstain from smoking on Sunday morning before receiving Holy Communion, then we should abstain from receiving Holy Communion until we put this vice under control. It is also appropriate to abstain from reading the newspaper, listening to the radio and turning the TV on, before going to church. Silence and quietude is the way to put ourselves in a prayerful frame of mind before going to church.¹¹⁴⁵

Holy Communion

- ◆ From the Didachae:
- ◆ “Do not let anyone eat or drink of your Eucharist except those who have been Baptized. On the Lord’s Day, gather in community to break bread and offer thanks. But confess your sins first, so that your sacrifice may be a pure one. No one who has a quarrel with his brother may join your gathering, not until they are reconciled. Your sacrifice must not be made unholy.” Teaching of the 12 Apostles 120AD
- ◆ Once the Clergy have received the Holy Eucharist, the faithful are then invited to come forward “with the fear of God, faith and love”. The reception of Holy Communion is a profession of faith, and we must pray that our Lord accept us at His Mystical Supper so that our participation may be for the “remission of sins and life everlasting.”

This is WHY we come



- ◆ The Holy Chalice has been raised high and invites all the faithful to “*come*” and to “*taste to see how good the Lord is*”
- ◆ **This is why we came to church: to partake in the Sacred Mysteries.**
- ◆ “*The first, primary, and most concrete manner of participation is Holy Communion. Sharing in the mystery of the body and blood of Christ is the deepest, most real way of participation, if we are properly prepared.*” Fr Stanley Harakās of blessed memory.
- ◆ The fear of God is often misunderstood period of course he is the God of love but if we don't have the fear of God in us, we won't have the love of God either. The scripture says “*fear God, and keep his commandments; for that is the whole duty of everyone. For God will bring every deed into judgment, including every secret thing, whether good or evil.*” Eccles. 12:13-14
- ◆ St. Tikon (1783) “*the fear of God will guard you and correct you everywhere and in all things, and will turn you away from every evil deed and confirm you in every good deed. Thus day by day you will become better.*”
- ◆ We hear the words: “*the servant of God _____ receives the body and blood of Christ for the remission of sins and life everlasting.*”
 - ▢ Saying ones name is acknowledging one is a servant of the Most High!



- ◆ *“Let us then rouse ourselves up and be filled with awe... that we may not, by approaching thoughtlessly and carelessly heap fire upon our heads... for this table is the sinews of our soul, the bond of our mind, the foundation of our confidence, our hope, our salvation our light, our life.”* CHR
 - ▢ Sinews means the parts of a structure, system, or thing that give it strength or bind it together; a piece of tough fibrous tissue uniting muscle to bone or bone to bone; a tendon or ligament.
- ◆ *“At minimum we should approach in an orderly fashion, respectfully and quietly, basic ingredients many times lacking...”* CHR
- ◆ What about the Communion Fast???
 - ▢ Many people commune at great feasts- Pascha, Christmas, Aug 15 - Because people fast, whereas at other times of the year some may not and because of this they may not approach the holy chalice when they should.

But what kind of Communion fast is prescribed by the church?

- ◆ In the 1st place we must address that fasting is one of the ways we prepare ourselves to receive Holy Communion.
- ◆ The second place we must emphatically state that there is no prescribed fasting for Holy Communion.
- ◆ The custom that prevailed since antiquity, which continues to be in effect to this day, is to abstain from eating and drinking on Sunday morning, and on any other morning on which one intends to receive Holy Communion. There is no other communion fasting – “No holy Canon prescribes that a faithful must fast before Holy Communion... the Holy Canons do not impose fasting prior to Holy Communion, neither do they prohibit it.” Arch. Christodoulos of Greece
- ◆ Canon 48 of the Synod in Carthage prescribes that the Holy Eucharist is not to be offered by priests who have eaten breakfast, which is repeated in Canon 56, which presents it as a Canon of the First Ecumenical Council. The content of these Canons is confirmed by Canon 29 of the 6th Ecumenical Council.

(technically from midnight on).¹¹⁷⁹ THERE IS NO OTHER COMMUNION FASTING.¹¹⁸⁰ A Christian who keeps the fasting days and periods prescribed by the Church can approach the Cup without any other "special" Communion fasting.

Preparing to receive Holy Communion by fasting one, two or three days "was unknown to the ancient Church."¹¹⁸¹ Besides such practice is against the Canons of the Church. Let us review the pertinent holy Canons of the Church. First, the 64th of the Holy Apostles: "If any Clergyman be found fasting on Sunday, or on Saturday with the exception of one only, let him be deposed from office. If, however, he is a layman, let him be excommunicated." According to this Canon we fast only on Holy Saturday ("one only"). Therefore if we fast on Saturday because we intend to receive Holy Communion on Sunday we violate this Canon. In fact, the Fathers of the Sixth Œcumenical Synod wrote a Canon (55th) addressed to the church of Rome in which they quote the above referenced Canon of the Holy Apostles, and enjoin the church of Rome from continuing their custom of fasting on the Saturdays of Great Lent. Finally with their Canon 66 the Fathers of the Sixth Œcumenical Synod prescribe that the Christians ought to commune daily during Bright Week.¹¹⁸² How could Christians receive Communion daily if they had to fast, at a time when fasting is prohibited by the Canons? By definition a day in which we receive the Holy Eucharist is not a fast day: "Can you make

wedding guests fast while the bridegroom is with them?" (Lk. 5:34).

Christians cut themselves off Holy Communion with their self-imposed Communion fast¹¹⁸³ and are scandalized when they see someone eating meat on Saturday and receive Holy Communion on Sunday. They should not be. If someone wants to abstain from meat, dairy products and even olive oil on Saturday, and eat something very light or nothing at all the night before, that is a commendable, pious practice, but it is not normative for all Christians. They should not expect others to follow their rule, and, even less, should they try to impose it on others and criticize them for receiving frequently the Holy Eucharist. It is sad to witness that self-imposed fasting has become the major obstacle from receiving Holy Communion regularly.

These same Christians would be shocked if they happened to be present at the Mystical Supper, when the Eucharist took place *during* the meal. Both Evangelists Matthew and Mark note that the Eucharist took place "as they were eating" (Mt. 26:16, Mk. 14:22). In the Apostolic age and in the early life of the Church the faithful did not keep a Eucharistic fast. "Fast, as a means of preparation for the divine Eucharist was unknown in the newly founded Church... since the Eucharist was taking place during or immediately after the communal meal"¹¹⁸⁴ (more on this subject in the following study).

Holy Communion

- ❖ *“In the first 3 centuries it was out of the question to take part in the celebration of the Eucharist and not to communicate, for Communion was the climax and the goal of the service. Regular perception of Communion was the means whereby those incorporated into Christ by Baptism were kept in His Body the Church. So important was it that in the 2nd century Deacons took Communion from the Church gathered for the celebration to the faithful who for good reason were unable to be present themselves.”* Hugh Wybrew
- ❖ It is through Communion we are united with Christ and with one another. **What is our justification for turning a cold ear to the Lord's invitation?** False reverence and pseudo-humility may be the reasons given by many today for abstaining or for self excusing them in partaking of the Sacred Gifts. Many faithful attend the Divine Liturgy and abstain from receiving out of a pietistic “tradition” they received from either a relative or someone they feared, and because of this, they cut themselves off in communion with the Lord, excommunicating themselves.
- ❖ Reception of Holy Communion is not dependent upon the “mood” the faithful happens to be in. This is a bad indicator and leaves us exposed to thoughts implanted in us by the devil to make us abstain from “the Cup of Salvation.” We should therefore come forward to receive the Holy Mysteries with clear conscience, a peaceful and serene mind, having done a thorough confession of our sins in and through humility, gratitude, thanksgiving, and relying on the Lord’s infinite love and mercy. **This means that we should be living our life as if we are receiving communion on a daily basis.**
 - ❑ Some may say...frequent reception by the faithful would mean a lengthening of the service.
 - ❑ Good that means all are partaking!!!